

## Divining Past, Present, and Future in the Sand

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A Geomantic Miscellany, ca. Sixteenth Century

TRANSLATED BY MATTHEW MELVIN-KOUSHKI

The Arabic practice of geomancy (*ilm al-raml*, or “the science of the sand”) was an occult science that ranked in popularity only behind astrology and oneiromancy, or dream divination, throughout the early modern Western (Islam-Judeo-Christian) world. Indeed, owing to its early incorporation of astrological correspondences, geomancy was often considered a form of “terrestrial astrology,” requiring much less astronomical expertise while remaining richly informative. As a divinatory science based on a binary code, it is an Arabic cognate to the *I Ching*, but was significantly more popular over a much larger area than the ancient Chinese oracle. Ottoman elites, like their Safavid and Mughal peers, were also greatly enamored of geomancy specifically for its political, military, and scientific applications. Court geomancers forecast the outcome of campaigns, battles, and sieges, as well as the economic ups and downs of the coming year, among other services rendered to the state. Beyond the court, physicians sometimes used geomancy to help diagnose illnesses, and judges used it to help decide court cases. Geomancy was just as attractive to the common man and woman, many of whom clearly relied on the advice of its professional practitioners for help navigating the hopes and fears of daily life.

The designation “science of the sand” refers to the original practice of drawing sixteen random series of lines in the sand or dirt to generate the first four tetragrams, or mothers, of a geomantic reading. These consisted of four lines of either one dot (odd) or two (even) in descending order, arranged from right to left. It was of the utmost importance that the geomancer be totally focused on the question at hand during this initial stage of the operation. The four mothers then generate four daughters, four nieces, two witnesses, one judge, and a final sentence, whereby 16 possible tetragrams or figures are assigned to these 16 houses according to a simple binary logic to produce a geomantic tableau.

So deployed, this binary code captured the flux patterns of the four elemental energies (fire, air, water, earth) as a means to divine past, present and future events, and indeed the status of everything in the sublunar realm. Each of the sixteen geomantic figures acquired a full suite of specific elemental, astrological, calendrical, numerical, lettrist, humoral, physiognomical, and other correspondences. The first twelve houses of the geomantic chart were likewise mapped onto the twelve planetary houses, and occasionally constructed in the form of a horoscope; astrological aspects (trine, sextile, square, opposition) were adopted as well. Detailed information could thus be derived from the figures and their relationships about virtually any aspect of human experience, whether physical, mental, or spiritual; past, present, or future. They revealed precise categories of data on numbers, letters, days, months, years, astral bodies, and divisions, body parts, physical and facial characteristics, minerals, precious stones, plants and plant products, animals and animal products, birds, fruits, tastes, colors, places, directions, regions, topographies, genders, social classes, nations, weapons, diseases, and so on.

To give a taste of this extremely popular divinatory practice in its Ottoman form, translated below are a few representative passages from a popular geomantic miscellany, presumably compiled in the sixteenth century at the latest, which features a random selection of excerpts and passages mainly in Persian but also in Arabic and Turkish, mostly by different hands. This miscellany offers us a crucial window onto the economic, social, political, familial, sexual, emotional, spiritual, and, yes, scientific life of the average inhabitant of the Ottoman Empire. Most interestingly, it features one of the most extensive—and idiosyncratic—lists of house-specific questions (below) in the entire Western tradition. A majority of the concerns raised and anxieties voiced are deeply familiar to us as present-day readers. In fact, the very personal and pragmatic queries this Persian-Turkish-Arabic geomantic miscellany preserves may be best described as an occult, early modern form of Googling—as well as Facebooking, wiretapping, trade forecasting, job seeking, CT scanning, ultrasounding, metal detecting, home surveilling, and radar.

LANGUAGE: The manuscript consists of an assortment of Persian, Turkish, and Arabic texts; the Persian and Arabic texts contain numerous grammatical and spelling errors. The translations here are all from Persian. Note that the table of house questions has been edited and slightly reduced for clarity.

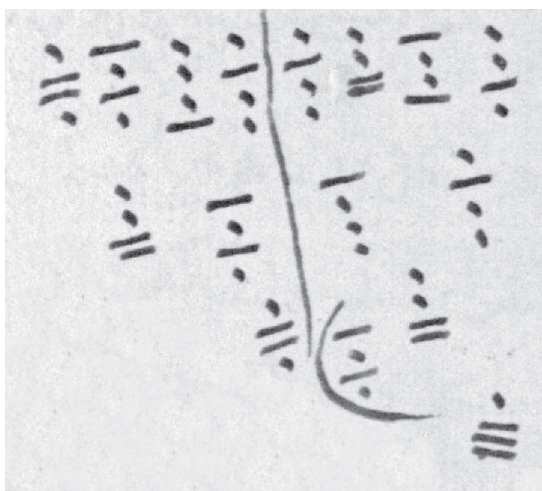
SOURCE: Manuscript: Anonymous, [*Mecmua-i Rem*], Adnan Ötügen İl Halk Kütüphanesi, Ankara, 06 Hk 5005; translated sections are on fols. 38b–39a, 47b–48a, and 7a–10b, respectively.

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If you want to diagnose injuries to the body, see in which house a seven- or five-dotted figure occurs, then to which body part that house corresponds; [the geomantic chart] indicates that is the part that has suffered injury. If the figure in question is auspicious, it will scar well; if it is inauspicious, it will not.

Also, wherever :: appears, the querent is particularly concerned about [matters relating to that house or houses].

FIGURE 25. Possible configuration of geomantic figures. Anonymous, [*Mecmua-i Reml*], 06 Hk 5005, fol. 39a. Adnan Ötüken İl Halk Kütüphanesi, Ankara.



Fire figures that occur in this house [i.e., the first] are stronger than the other figures; thus [an initial]  $\ddot{\vdots}$  is stronger than even  $\ddot{\vdots}$ , [which is normally the strongest figure].

Also, fixed figures that occur in this house are bad, and indicate that the querent will be frustrated in all his or her undertakings. And if the figure in the first house is repeated in the second, the querent is greatly preoccupied [with their question]. If the figures are weak, their thoughts will be negative; from that figure what he or she is thinking may be known. Thus, if it is  $\ddot{\vdots}$ , the querent is fearing death or worrying about financial liquidity, and so on.

The ascendant of a person's birth is likewise told from the first house, and that of their conception from the third. If someone wants to find out their ascendant, there are two methods [for determining it]. Either see where  $\ddot{\vdots}$  is or see whether the figure in the first house is repeated anywhere. If in the second house, the querent's ascendant is Taurus; if in the third, Gemini; if in the fourth, Cancer; and so on.

If the first figure is not repeated, however, it indicates distress on the part of the querent. For example, say a female client has geomantic charts cast, and this chart is produced:

[The geomancer] will first say, "You're unable to properly focus on your work, and want to know why. But we don't find  $\ddot{\vdots}$  [in the main body of the chart], and the  $\ddot{\vdots}$  in the first house is not repeated. But we find  $\ddot{\vdots}$  [being repeated] instead of  $\ddot{\vdots}$ , [so the latter] here refers to your husband, who's on a trip—[that's why you're distracted]." The point is that it would be easier [to make an accurate reading in this example] were the initial  $\ddot{\vdots}$  to be repeated or if  $\ddot{\vdots}$  were present [in the main body of the chart]. The special property of each figure in each house is laid out in the following table. [. . .]

[An example from this table:] *Horizon Seven, Relating to Marriage, and so on*. First see what associations of this house are present and what are absent. Thus, when a querent seeks judgment [in this respect] see where  $\ddot{\vdots}$  occurs, as it governs [questions related to this house], and whether it is strong or weak, as well as the witnesses and any aspects—trine, square,

sextile, opposition, conjunction—that it makes, which are among the necessary elements, and derive the judgment from those.

Thus if the question is asked, “How many times will I marry?” seek the answer from the units [cycle], or the sixth house. The geomancer should also ask how many marriages or how many daughters [the querent will have]. But just ☸ by itself here does not suffice, since it also relates to absent relatives and partners and thieves, as was discussed above. [As that may be], judgment is made on the basis of the strength or weakness [of this figure]. As for an impending marriage [as a legal act], judgment should be sought from the eighth house. Four figures in this house indicate marriage, all of them mutable, and here greatly strengthened: ☸ ☸ ☸ ☸.

If it is asked whether one’s wife will be old or young, tell that from the repetition of [the figure in house] seven. If ☸ or auspicious figures cardinal or fixed or ☸, then she will be young. Also, if the querent asks about the quality of the family from which his wife will hail, look to the seventh house: if Tristitia or Carcer occurs there, she will be of bad stock, but if ☸ or ☸, her people will be noble. [. . .]

## QUESTIONS APPROPRIATE TO THE SIXTEEN GEOMANTIC HOUSES

### HOUSE ONE

Will I be happy or not?  
How will my request work out?  
Will I gain power or fame in the near future?  
What’s my horoscope, and is it auspicious or not?  
The beginning of any business.  
How will today be?  
When will I die?

### HOUSE TWO

Will I have income or not?  
Is he or she poor or rich?  
Will it be beneficial or not?  
What would be a good source of income?  
Will my associate come or not?  
Will I make more than I spend or vice versa?  
When will the money arrive?  
Where will my livelihood come from?

Will it be sold or not?

Is he or she generous or stingy?

Will I be able to purchase it soon?

How will my purchase turn out?

How will I make a living?

What’s going on with my property?

Will I receive a gift?

Will the lost object be found or not?

Tracking a lost object;

Is the lost object simply lost or was it stolen?

Will my loan be repaid or not?

Will my absent relative return?

How’s my friend doing?

Will the trade go through or not?

What’s for dinner?

### HOUSE THREE

Will a victory be possible on this campaign?

How are my relatives doing?

How did an old concern turn out?  
 Will it be possible to move an item, and if so when?  
 Seeing relatives in your dreams.  
 How are things at home?  
 Will there be a way?  
 I sent a messenger—[will he or she arrive?]  
 How goes it with the messenger en route?  
 When will the messenger arrive?  
 Will the person I summoned come?  
 Will they be found alive or dead?  
 Whether someone is knowledgeable or ignorant.  
 What will the end of my life be like?  
 Going to market or going home.  
 Will news arrive from abroad or not?  
 The beginning of a journey.  
 How will my visit to the bathhouse be?  
 Traveling through the desert.  
 How will this business turn out?  
 Does the dream I had last night mean anything?  
 Should I go for it?

#### HOUSE FOUR

How many people are outside the house right now?  
 How are my children doing?  
 Will the pregnant woman give birth to a healthy child?  
 Construction of a building or pool.  
 Making a sitting area or erecting a column.  
 Will I have another child?  
 How will I pass my life?

What's this place like?  
 How's my father doing?  
 Will my property be taken from me?  
 How will my associate's trip go?  
 How is the city?  
 What livelihood will I finally settle on?  
 Should I bury my money or not?  
 Is there hidden treasure or not?  
 What's that place like?  
 Will I be able to leave this place?  
 Tree planting and the harvest.  
 Will it be planted?  
 How's the king's wife?  
 Is it being stored or transported?  
 What profit will I have from this purchase?  
 Will I be able to trade?  
 Will I be able to sell?  
 Property of one's brother or associate.  
 Safe or dangerous?  
 Coming or going?  
 How many associates or brothers will I have?

#### HOUSE FIVE

Taking medicine.  
 Is this food appropriate [to my condition]?  
 What's the status of my illness or heart problem?  
 [Will] this physician's treatment [work]?  
 Does the physician know what he's doing or not?  
 Will my child be male or female?  
 What will my child's horoscope be?

Is the news true?  
 Revenue from property.  
 When will news arrive from the  
     countryside?  
 A brother's traveling.  
 Will the pregnant woman have an easy  
     birth?  
 Death of the king.  
 Wrestling.  
 Treachery.  
 Archery.  
 Boozing.  
 Gaming.  
 When will the messenger come?  
 Will the messenger have valuable  
     information?  
 Will my lover come or not?  
 Will my gift reach him or her?  
 Will a gift reach me?  
 Someone's being friendly—is he or she  
     sincere?  
 Will I find relief from this sadness?  
 How's my lover doing?  
 What news does the bey have?  
 What will I eat today?

#### HOUSE SIX

Will the secret stay a secret or not?  
 Tracking an escapee.  
 Will the slave be freed or not?  
 What was lost?  
 Who am I thinking of?  
 Where's the lost person or escapee?  
 How are my chickens or sheep doing?

Has a spell been cast or not?  
 What kind of cattle?  
 How will the chicken trade go?  
 Has the eye been injured or not?  
 Will these cattle stay or escape?  
 Has my turtledove, hawk, or falcon died?  
 What's the status of the illness?  
 A slave asking, "Will I be sold?"  
 Will any harmful creatures come here or  
     not?  
 Will I be freed or not?  
 Will my children help me?  
 How's my servant?  
 Will the captive be sold or not?  
 How's the hunt going?  
 How's the captive?  
 How's the student?  
 Should I get surgery, and if so, how will it  
     go?  
 Is this captive special?  
 How are the cows and the cowherd?  
 Disasters and accidents.  
 Did my captive go off with my animals or  
     were they stolen?  
 How's the captive or hostage doing?  
 How are my brothers doing?  
 Will the lost object be found or not?

#### HOUSE SEVEN

Was it stolen?  
 What's the mayor of the city I'm traveling to  
     like?  
 The state of someone who's away.  
 Safety of the roads.

Is someone who's away about to die, or has he been revived?  
 Is the person away still alive or not?  
 Did this person go there and how is it?  
 Looking for a wife.  
 What is the woman like?  
 Is the woman a virgin or not?  
 A woman's pedigree and good character—or lack thereof.  
 Sex talk.  
 A woman's beauty and grace.  
 The condition of a caravan.  
 When will the traveler arrive?  
 Separation and cutting ties.  
 If I go looking for someone, will I find her or him?  
 My future standing.  
 Enemies and opponents.  
 Will they oppose me?  
 Where's my enemy from?  
 If I make an allegation, will it stick?  
 Entering into a partnership.  
 Striking a deal.  
 Will a deal be struck or not?

#### HOUSE EIGHT

Will my property return to me?  
 My lover's father.  
 How a trip will go.  
 Will I travel or not?  
 Taking out a loan.  
 A father's illness.  
 Will my inheritance come?  
 Returning from a journey.

What kind of fear?  
 The status of a beloved.  
 A father's lover.  
 Acquiring an education.  
 Will I have bad luck or not?  
 The wife of an associate.  
 Return on investment.  
 A father's child.  
 Giving charity.  
 Will I get anything from the treasury?  
 Will I find protection?  
 Interpreting a dream.  
 Is the dream I had last night accurate or not?  
 What did they dream about?  
 Disappeared property.  
 Will anyone be suspicious?  
 Will it be found?  
 When will I die?  
 What's the current status of this Islam?  
 Ritual worship and pilgrimage.  
 Slaves' departure.  
 A brother's illness.  
 Cause of death.  
 A brother's servant.  
 Should we expect it or not?  
 The current state of a wife or partner.  
 The wife of a collaborator.  
 Grandchildren.

#### HOUSE NINE

Is this road safe?  
 How did the job go?

Will I achieve my goal?  
 A letter from the king.  
 Having an audience with the king.  
 The current state of the king or governor.  
 A brother's wife.  
 What's the best thing to do?  
 My lover's lover.  
 The end result of a job.  
 A father's partner.  
 Will I achieve fame?  
 Making talismans.  
 Doing astrology and geomancy.  
 Will I be divinely graced if I write out this invocation?  
 How much money will I make?  
 The return of someone who was away.  
 How's my mother?  
 Will I profit from my father's trip?  
 Is this man a spy?  
 Is this a prudent thing to do or not?  
 Is this clean or not?  
 Between two or three options, which is the best?

#### HOUSE TEN

Should I go to the judge?  
 Are [fruits] being eaten from my trees?  
 What's the thief doing?  
 A woman's final state.  
 Will it produce?  
 A woman's property.  
 Will my current prestige last or not?  
 Storms and lightning.

Should I travel to trade or not?  
 Will it rain or not?  
 How will the craftwork turn out?  
 My relationship to the king.  
 Will my luck change for the better or the worse?  
 Will God have mercy?  
 The state of my father's wife.  
 The property of a wife or partner.  
 The end result of a partner's condition.  
 What will my child be like?  
 Glory and humiliation.

#### HOUSE ELEVEN

The king's wealth.  
 Is the court order forthcoming?  
 Will the official sealed letter arrive?  
 Will I benefit from the king's wealth?  
 A mother's property.  
 The current state of friends.  
 Meeting up with friends.  
 Was the promise true?  
 Will my hope be realized?  
 A brother's journey.  
 A father's death.  
 Reunion with a lover.  
 How's my lover?  
 Marrying one's lover.  
 What is my lover's enemy like?  
 A son or daughter's marriage.  
 A daughter's husband.  
 An old woman.  
 Is the woman's lover a leech?



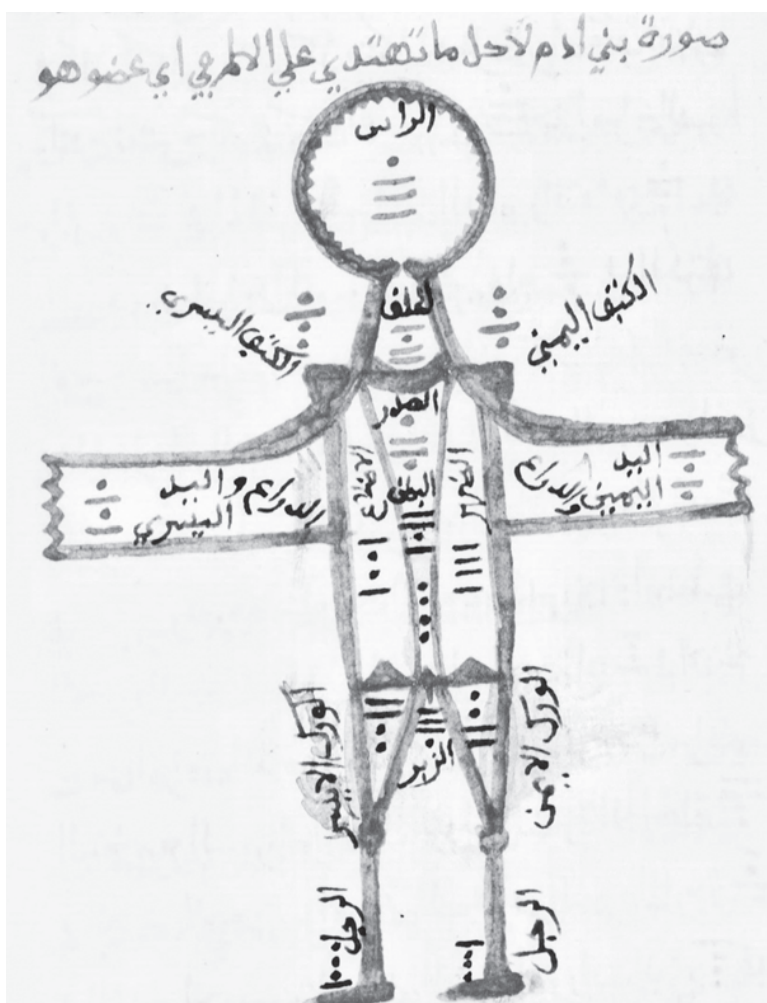


FIGURE 26. Human limbs as they correspond to sixteen geomantic figures.  
*Kitab fi ilm al-raml*, Département des manuscrits. Arabe 2631, fol. 66b.  
 Bibliothèque nationale de France, Paris.

## HOUSE TWELVE

A large animal or slave.

Should I go against him?

How an enemy will end up.

War and peace.

Buying a beast of burden.

The current state of a great enemy.

Freeing the imprisoned.

Fighting an enemy.

Current condition of the prison and its inmates.

What should I do to get the result I want?

Catching doves or pigeons.

Will this worry pass?

Will I face poverty and misery?

Is this jewel authentic?

Will it happen?  
Will they repay my loan?  
Should I have my blood let?  
Is what they're saying about him or her true?

#### HOUSE THIRTEEN

What's my question?  
Weakness and strength.  
Will I be safe from these events?  
When will this idea stop bothering me?  
When will my mind be happy?  
Drawing out water.  
Distant journeys.  
A mother's final state.  
A king's final state.  
Favor from the king.  
The status of a mother.  
The partner of a partner.

#### HOUSE FOURTEEN

Will I achieve my goal?  
Will my prayer be answered?  
What kind of creature will fulfill my prayer?  
Is speaking without listening appropriate?  
Has the news been verified?  
Expensive or cheap?  
Will money come soon on this trip or not?  
A friend's status.  
Should I go hunting or not?  
The brother of an enemy.  
An enemy on the move.

A mother's child.  
The king's friend.

#### HOUSE FIFTEEN

Will my representative fight for me?  
Will the judge decide in my favor?  
The state of the grave.  
Will it be gathered or scattered?  
Studying philosophy.  
Wisdom and corruption.  
Economy and waste.  
Will it go bad or not?  
Will it be a boy or a girl?  
Should I confiscate it or not?  
Should I educate myself or not?  
Will the news remain known only to me?  
Should I make an accusation or not?  
Should I consult on this problem or not?  
Is this person sick or not?

#### HOUSE SIXTEEN

The result of the result.  
Will he achieve his goal?  
What will my afterlife be like?  
Supervising and checking work.  
Will I achieve my goal in the end?  
The suffering of friends.  
Should I say this?  
Will news of my enemy arrive or not?  
Will it be in my interest or not?  
How will the confluence of all these events turn out?  
Will the tax owed be paid?